THE OUTLIER STATES

1. UTTAR PRADESH

Challenge: *Balance aspirations of dominant non-Yadav OBCs, bridge organisation/ govt gap*

X-factors: *Yogi's choice, PM Modi's nod*

2. MANIPUR

Challenge: *Security scenarios*

X-factor: *State is in flux*

3. KARNATAKA

Challenge: *Delhi backs B.Y. Vijayendra, rivals fuming*

X-factors: *Lingayat legacy, BSY's grip on caste matrix*

4. JHARKHAND

Challenge: *Balancing tribal and OBC aspirations*

X-factor: *Sangh diktat*

5. GUJARAT

Challenge: *Patidar vs OBC vs Rajput equations*

X-factor: *Modi's choice*

6. HARYANA

Challenge: *Khattar's shadow is too obvious*

X-factor: *Ex-CM's pick may prevail, at least for now*

7. DELHI

Challenge: *BJP is in power in Centre, state as well as MCD**. Need a candidate who can deliver*

X-factor: *Modi-Shah vision has to align with Sangh's*

***MCD: Municipal Corporation of Delhi*

Basavaraj Bommai. Those opposed are adamant, saying "anyone but Vijayendra". The central leadership is in a fix as well: they know that apart from BSY and his son, no one can rally the key Lingayat base.
Gujarat: Current state chief C.R. Patil is now a Union minister, which disqualifies him under the party's one-person, one-post norm. CM Bhupendra Patel's camp and a consolidation of OBC leaders are jockeying for influence. It's PM Modi's home state, and the party has to decide: send a leader from Delhi or pick someone local who complements the state government.
Uttar Pradesh: CM Yogi Adityanath's growing influence has made many in Delhi wary. Appointing someone close to him may reduce the state unit to a rubber stamp. But choosing an outsider could accentuate conflict. A state cabinet reshuffle and a new governor are also on the anvil. There is also the Union cabinet reshuffle, which could see various MPs being 'readjusted'. All this could alter power equations in the state and, with the 2027 assembly polls approaching, the party must act fast.
Haryana: Despite ex-CM M.L. Khattar's shift to Delhi, his shadow looms large. Protégé Mohan Lal Badoli is seeking re-election as state chief, backed by CM Nayab Singh Saini, but some Khattar loyalists are not enthused, arguing he's too close to the current CM. Union minister Rao Inderjit Singh, an ex-Congressman-turned-BJP heavyweight and known Khattar-baiter, has signalled his interest by hosting a dinner that 12 MLAs from the Ahirwal region (south Haryana) attended.
Delhi: The BJP has never been so strong in the national capital—it swept all seven LS seats and crushed the Aam Aadmi Party in the assembly polls. Yet, state president Virendra Sachdeva is on a weak wicket, with calls for a more dynamic replacement.
Jharkhand: The organisational poll was delayed because of the assembly poll, and the unexpected defeat there has led to a rise in factionalism. Veteran Babulal Marandi's relevance is fading. The JMM-Congress alliance retained its tribal base in both the assembly and Lok Sabha polls. The BJP must decide whether to project a tribal face or rely on OBC mobilisation.
Punjab: The experiment with Congress turncoat Sunil Jakhar has failed. On July 7, the party appointed Ashwani Sharma, a veteran with strong RSS credentials, as working president. He's been asked to wrap up the elections for mandal and district chiefs. The death of state in-charge Vijay Rupani in the Air India crash in June had stalled that work. The state unit remains in flux.

THE LONG GAME

The BJP has fulfilled the quorum to elect a national president, but the delay suggests an internal debate. The Sangh reportedly prefers a traditionalist with deep ideological moorings. The Modi-Shah camp may want someone more attuned to coalition politics and electoral pragmatism. A Union cabinet reshuffle is also on the cards, with voices on both sides calling for ministers who haven't contributed to the organisation to step down.

What's evident is that the Sangh is no longer content to play second fiddle. It is not just shaping this round of state appointments, but also the central leadership transition. Finally, this moment isn't just about a procedural backlog, it is a contest over ideological direction. As one BJP insider asks, is the BJP still Modi's centralised machine, or is it drifting back to the Sangh's decentralised, cadre-first ethos? That question is being answered, slowly but surely. ■

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